

Staff Facilitation Guide

Social & Recreational Group Activities

This guide helps direct support staff plan, run, and wrap up group social and recreational activities for individuals with developmental disabilities. Use it as a quick reference before, during, and after every group session.

1 BEFORE THE ACTIVITY

Know Your Group

- Review each participant's support plan, communication needs, and sensory preferences.
- Check for any behavioral goals or specific triggers to be aware of.
- Note any mobility, vision, or hearing considerations that affect activity set-up.
- Identify who may need 1:1 support vs. who works well independently.

Plan the Activity

- Choose an activity matched to the group's interests, abilities, and energy levels.
- Set a clear goal: is this about fun, connection, skill-building, or all three?
- Have a backup plan for if the activity isn't working.
- Prepare a simple visual schedule or cue cards if your group benefits from them.

Pre-Activity Checklist

	Space set up and accessible (wide aisles, appropriate seating)
	All materials gathered and within reach
	Sensory supports ready (noise-cancelling headphones, fidget tools, etc.)
	Visual schedule or cue cards prepared
	Communication devices charged and accessible
	Transition warning plan in place (5-min, 2-min cues)
	Emergency/behavior support contacts confirmed

2 SETTING THE STAGE

Environment	Welcoming Participants
• Arrange seating in a circle or U-shape so everyone can see each other	• Greet each participant by name as they arrive
• Reduce visual clutter and distractions in the activity area	• Give a warm, simple welcome and preview what's happening today

• Ensure adequate lighting — not too bright or too dim	• Offer a choice of where to sit when possible
• Have sensory breaks clearly signed or available nearby	• Allow 2–3 minutes of settling time before starting
• Post the visual schedule where all participants can see it	• Confirm communication supports are in place

■ 3 RUNNING THE ACTIVITY

Opening the Session

- State the activity clearly in plain language: "Today we are going to play bingo."
- Walk through the steps or rules — use visuals if available.
- Ask a simple check-in: "How is everyone feeling today?" (thumbs, emojis, words).
- Remind participants of any group agreements (taking turns, using kind words).

Facilitating Participation

Strategy	How to Do It
Offer choices	Give 2–3 options to support autonomy: "Do you want the red piece or the blue piece?"
Use least-to-most prompting	Start with a gesture or expectant look before giving verbal or physical prompts.
Narrate positively	Describe what participants are doing well: "Great job waiting for your turn, Marcus!"
Keep pace flexible	Some participants need extra processing time — pause and wait before repeating.
Include everyone	Actively invite quieter participants; never force participation, but keep the door open.
Use simple language	Short sentences. Concrete words. Repeat key instructions without changing the wording.
Celebrate effort	Praise participation and effort, not just success: "You tried so hard — nice work!"

Tip: If the activity is going well — resist the urge to over-facilitate. Let participants lead, problem-solve, and interact with each other. Your job shifts from instructor to supportive observer.

■ 4 MANAGING CHALLENGES

Challenge	Response
Disengagement	Offer a modified role (e.g., score-keeper, materials helper). Lower the demand temporarily.
Escalating behavior	Stay calm. Reduce stimulation. Offer a break space. Follow the individual's behavior support plan.
Conflict between participants	Acknowledge both perspectives. Re-state group agreements. Redirect to the activity.

Activity too hard	Simplify the task, provide a model, or offer hand-over-hand support.
Activity too easy	Add a challenge layer: "Can you do it with your non-dominant hand?" or a friendly competition.
Sensory overload	Offer noise-reducing headphones, a quieter seat, or a brief sensory break.
Late arrivals / transitions	Welcome without disrupting the group. Quietly orient them to what's happening.

■ 5 CLOSING THE ACTIVITY

Transition Warnings

- Give a 5-minute warning: "We have 5 more minutes of activity time."
- Give a 2-minute warning with a visual cue if needed.
- Announce the ending clearly: "Activity time is finished. Great job everyone!"

Group Wrap-Up

- Invite participants to share a highlight: "What was your favourite part today?"
- Acknowledge specific contributions: "I noticed you helped pick up the cards — thank you."
- Preview what is coming next to support smooth transitions.
- Lead a simple cool-down if energy is high (slow breathing, a calm song).

Closing rituals build predictability and safety. Consider ending every session the same way: a group high-five, a shared word, or a goodbye song.

■ 6 AFTER THE SESSION — DOCUMENTATION

Complete documentation on the same day. Record factual observations — what happened, not interpretations. Keep notes person-centred and strengths-focused.

Documentation Checklist

- Activity name, date, time, location, and staff present
- Participants who attended (including any who chose not to participate)
- Level of participation for each individual (active, partial, observer)
- Notable successes, positive moments, or skill demonstrations
- Any behavioral incidents — factual description, response used, outcome
- Equipment or environment issues to flag
- Recommendations for next session (modifications, new activities, etc.)

■ 7 QUICK REFERENCE — FACILITATION REMINDERS

Follow the person's lead	Interests, pace, and choices should drive the session.
Presume competence	Assume participants can engage and adapt tasks, not skip them.
Stay regulated yourself	Your calm is contagious. Slow down if you feel flustered.
Less is more	Too many instructions or materials can overwhelm. Introduce one step at a time.
Ask, don't tell	"Would you like to try?" beats "Now you have to do this."
Debrief with your team	A 5-minute check-in after each session improves the next one.

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